Michelle Layvant

Department of Agricultural and Resource Economics, University of California, Berkeley
mlayvant@berkeley.edu | michellelayvant.com | +1 (847) 977-8056

Education

University of California, Berkeley 2021–present
Ph.D. Candidate in Agricultural and Resource Economics

University of California, Berkeley 2012–2015
B.A. in Economics, Minor in Public Policy

Research Fields

Development Economics, Behavioral Economics, and Labor Economics

References

Edward Miguel
Dept. of Economics
University of California, Berkeley
emiguel@berkeley.edu

Jeremy Magruder
Dept. of Agricultural and Resource Economics
University of California, Berkeley
jmagruder@berkeley.edu

Dmitry Taubinsky
Dept. of Economics
University of California, Berkeley
dmitry.taubinsky@berkeley.edu

Gautam Rao
Haas School of Business & Dept. of Economics
University of California, Berkeley
grao@berkeley.edu

Job Market Paper

Committed to Education: School Fees, Vouchers, and the Timing of Cash Transfers
with Gonzalo Ferres

Abstract. Primary-school dropout remains widespread in Sub-Saharan Africa, and school fees are a major barrier to completion. In an experiment with 2,000 parents in eastern Uganda, we study whether time-inconsistent preferences help explain why fees go unpaid. We elicit parents' willingness to pay for two restrictions on a cash transfer, delaying it until fees are due and, holding timing fixed, earmarking it as a voucher paid directly to the school. Demand for both restrictions is substantial. Sixty-nine percent of parents are willing to pay for earmarking and 62 percent for delay. We then randomly assign parents to receive the same amount as cash six weeks before fees are due, as cash when fees are due, as a voucher, or no transfer. Both cash transfers modestly increase fee payment, with no additional effect from delay. In contrast, the voucher substantially increases fee payment and reduces within-term dropout by more than half, without detectably worse household outcomes. Fee-day cash and the voucher also raise school attendance. The voucher's effects on fee payment and attendance are at least as large among parents who prefer cash as among those who prefer the voucher. This divergence partly reflects misprediction. Parents substantially underestimate the effect of earmarking on their own fee payment. In a model of quasi-hyperbolic discounting, these findings are consistent with partial naïveté, in which parents anticipate their own time inconsistency but underestimate its severity.

Working Papers

Impacts of Secondary School in Kenya after Two Decades
with Edward Miguel, Owen Ozier, and Michael Walker

Abstract. A crucial 8th grade standardized test creates a discontinuity that causes otherwise similar students to have different probabilities of attending and completing secondary school in Kenya. Following survey respondents for nearly two decades after that test, we estimate the long-run effects of secondary schooling on fertility, cognition, and economic outcomes. We find large and persistent declines in realized fertility among men, exceeding one child on average, but, perhaps surprisingly, no detectable fertility effects among women. We also document durable improvements in adult cognitive performance, with gains of roughly 0.2 standard deviations for both men and women. These benefits appear to extend across generations: the children of those induced into secondary schooling perform better on cognitive measures, with effects concentrated among the children of female respondents. In contrast, we find limited evidence of long-run gains in earnings or household consumption.

Publications

Walker, M. W., Huang, A. H., Asman, S., Baird, S. J., Fernald, L., Hamory Hicks, J., Hoces de la Guardia, F., Koiso, S., Kremer, M., Krupoff, M. N., **Layvant, M.**, Ochieng, E., Suri, P., and Miguel, E. "Intergenerational Child Mortality Impacts of Deworming: Experimental Evidence from Two Decades of the Kenya Life Panel Survey." *American Economic Journal: Applied Economics*, forthcoming.

Ma, X., **Layvant, M.**, Miguel, E., Ochieng, E., Pillarisetti, A., and Walker, M. W. "Impacts of Contemporaneous Air Pollution Exposure on Cognitive Performance in Kenya." *Journal of Health Economics*, 109:103166, 2026.

Gross, A. L., Duhon, M., Ochieng, E., Ikanga, J. N., Dow, W. H., Lee, J., Walker, M. W., **Layvant, M.**, Ngugi, A., Ehrlich, J. R., and Miguel, E. A. "Midlife Cognitive Testing in Africa: Validity of the Harmonised Cognitive Assessment Protocol in the Kenya Life Panel Survey." *BMJ Open*, 15(8), 2025.

Grants and Fellowships

2026

Giannini Foundation of Agricultural Economics	$35,000
Rocca Dissertation Fellowship, UC Berkeley Center for African Studies	$11,000
John L. Simpson ABD Fellowship, UC Berkeley	$1,000

2025

Development Challenge Awards, Center for Effective Global Action (two awards)	$12,150; $12,000

2024

Learning for All, Abdul Latif Jameel Poverty Action Lab (J-PAL)	$60,768
The Weiss Fund, University of Chicago	$39,498
CEDA Pilot Grant, Center on the Economics and Demography of Aging	$28,400
Development Challenge Award, Center for Effective Global Action	$15,000
John L. Simpson ABD Fellowship, UC Berkeley	$10,000

2023

Gender Economics Research Award, UC Berkeley Economics	$9,000

Teaching

University of California, Berkeley

Business and Production of Beer, Wine, and Spirits	2021–23, 2025–26
Population, Environment, and Development	2024
Case Studies in Economic Development	2023

Research Assistance

University of California, Berkeley

Graduate Research Assistant to Edward Miguel	present
Graduate Research Assistant to Ethan Ligon	2023–2024
Undergraduate Research Assistant to David Card	2014–2015

Center for Effective Global Action

Research Assistant to Edward Miguel	2019–2022

Partners In Health

Pro-Bono Researcher	2016–2020

Presentations

UC Berkeley Development Lunch; UC Berkeley Development Workshop (x2); CEGA Research Retreat	2026
UC Berkeley Development Lunch (x2); UC Berkeley Development Workshop (x2)	2025
UC Berkeley Development Lunch (x2); UC Berkeley Development Workshop (x2); CEGA Evidence Action Summit; Population Association of America	2024
UC Berkeley Development Workshop; CEGA Working Group in African Political Economy	2023
UC Berkeley Aging in Africa	2022

Service to the Profession

Mentoring: East Africa Social Science Translation Collaborative, UC Berkeley (Spring 2023, Fall 2023)